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“What Happens [in Vegas]”: Performing the Post-Tourist *Flâneur* in “New York” and “Paris”

Andrew F. Wood

This essay explores Las Vegas as a stage-set for tourist performance. Initially, I outline Walter Benjamin’s notion of the flâneur as a framework for my study before addressing two foci of this paper: (1) the site of Las Vegas as “omnitopian” enclosure and (2) the performance of Las Vegas through post-tourism. Following this analysis, I discuss consequences of inauthentic post-tourist play as imagined by critics of “mere pleasure.”

Keywords: Flâneur; Las Vegas; Omnitopia; Post-Tourism; Souvenirs

The whispering of gazes fills the arcades. There is no thing here that does not, where one least expects it, open a fugitive eye, blinking it shut again; and should you look more closely, it is gone. To the whispering of these gazes, the space lends its echo: “Now, what,” it blinks, “can possibility have come over me?” (Walter Benjamin c°, 3/878)¹

I stand atop the Eiffel Tower, gazing over the Nevada desert.

In order to reach this summit, I pay nine dollars to ride an escalator, cross a bridge, and enter a lift. Along the way, I pause by a poster reproduced from the 1889 Paris Exposition; a little boy peers upward through a looking glass. I imagine him staring at the tower before reading his exclamation: “*Je Peux Voir Le Sommet!*” Before I am permitted to climb to the top of this tower, I must cross a walkway that leads to the elevator. There, I am instructed to stop at a velvet rope before being admitted into a photography area. The photographer instructs me to place my bags on the floor and positions me in two poses, one standing arms outstretched. I am assured that this position conveys my excitement to be here. The photographer’s assistant hands me

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one ticket for each photo and helpfully reminds me that I can purchase prints downstairs.

I enter the elevator, climb 460 feet, and exit onto the observation deck. Buffeted by the warm desert breeze, I hear the unzipping of camera bags and watch as fellow tourists reenact the discipline of the photography area. They busy themselves with technical details and position each other in poses that strike me as “typical”: looking out over the landscape or smiling directly at the photographer. Their digital cameras emit an electronic “shutter click” sound that reminds me of old SLR cameras. I circle the observation deck and spot the faux towers of New York-New York, imagining an invisible axis between these two places. I am a researcher contemplating what Roland Barthes called a “new sensibility of vision” (9). I am also a tourist taking pictures in Las Vegas.

Before long, two young women walk past me, smiling at each other and fiddling with their cameras. They are wearing good walking shoes and short white socks. One leans upon the railing to gaze at the awesome vista of tall buildings and streets that shimmer in the summer heat. Then, for just a moment, she jerks her head back and forth with frenzied enthusiasm. Her friend laughs and I instantly recall the scene from *National Lampoon’s Vacation*. With her manic performance, the woman has become (at least for me) Clark Griswold seeking to capture the majesty of the Grand Canyon in one hyperkinetic gaze. At once, the Eiffel Tower is dragged from the desert and merged with the well-known comedy before providing an example for my essay. Detached at least four ways from the Paris that is “real,” I’m beginning to see that “what happens here” may not be restricted entirely to Las Vegas.

What Happens Here

Beginning with its advertising campaign, “what happens here, stays here,” Las Vegas abandoned efforts to transform its “Sin City” reputation into a family-friendly destination—oriented around “gaming,” of course.² Starting in 2003, television spots began to depict titillating scenes from tourist fantasies that revealed just enough plot (and sometimes, just enough skin) to indicate that consequence-free “adult play” and all-night debauchery awaited even the most staid tourists. In one spot, a woman engages in steamy flirtation with a limo driver, but after exiting the car, she adopts the guise of a business professional. The advertisement conveys a simple and compelling message: in Las Vegas, she (and you) can be both. However, I believe that the campaign works on another level as well: the advertising complicates the totalizing power of Las Vegas to contain and restrain performances of tourism. To be sure, the campaign employs a certain “enclavic rhetoric”—Las Vegas contains a world of its own that is a world apart—and yet I propose that such enclaves are much more permeable than they might appear.

To advance this notion, I focus my attention on the stage upon (and within) which these tourist performances may be found. Here, I enter a conversation about tourist performances that has arisen from several recent articles in *Text and Performance Quarterly* exploring the roles of pilgrimage, souvenirs, and identity within tourist

locales.³ Reviewing these essays within the context of interdisciplinary tourism research, I believe we should consider more carefully the role of “authenticity” in the place and performance of tourism. How “real” are the places that tourists visit, and how “real” are tourists themselves? One typical response is to critique tourist environments as unreal and then celebrate how tourists manage to craft genuine and meaningful experiences. While admitting a personal affinity with this notion, I nonetheless hold that the search for “authenticity” does not necessarily express the embodied experience of tourism, particularly in a *milieu* of late modern capitalism. Instead, the performance of fakery, the ironically recited identity of the tourist who finds resonance within the “what happens here” campaign—the purposeful construction of *inauthenticity*: these reflect a lens upon places like Las Vegas. And as the urban world appears to “learn . . . from Las Vegas,” we are wise to explore its complex spaces as a site that inspires increasingly ubiquitous performances (Venturi, Brown, and Izenour 53). Here, I offer a tentative exploration of Las Vegas as a stage-set for tourist performance. Initially, I outline Walter Benjamin’s notion of the *flâneur* as a framework for my study before addressing two foci of this paper: (1) the site of Las Vegas as “omnitopian” enclosure and (2) the performance of Las Vegas through post-tourism. Following this analysis, I discuss consequences of inauthentic post-tourist play as imagined by critics of “mere pleasure.”

Strolling Las Vegas

As a participant-observer of tourist environments, I was particularly drawn to Tracy Stephenson Shaffer’s call for researchers to “come to understand how tourists sense a place by ‘becoming’ tourists themselves, literally putting the tourist back in his or her body and looking for insights gleaned in the doing” (141). To that end, I visited the Las Vegas Strip for four days in February 2005 and two more days in July 2005, spending most of my time in two casino hotels, New York-New York and Paris-Las Vegas. Collecting field observations, taking photographs, listening to conversations, and wandering from venue to venue, I encountered Las Vegas as more than a coercive text with faceless authors, but as a performance with an editable script. Of course, this standpoint is hardly unique. Indeed, my strolls through Las Vegas draw much from Walter Benjamin’s musings on the *flâneur*.⁴

Walter Benjamin’s *flâneur* enters the urban environment in a manner both detached and personal. For this figure, “[t]he city splits . . . into its dialectical poles. It opens . . . as a landscape, even as it closes . . . as a room” (M1,4/417).⁵ Entering this city, transforming its exterior designs into an interior monologue (a long “passage,” in at least two senses of the word), the *flâneur* is typically imagined as a heroic figure, the one who knows. Walking slowly, the *flâneur* enacts a series of movements and glances: simultaneously gazing upon the entire scene and becoming lost in the labyrinth. Turning this way and that, pausing to wipe the dust off a rusting sign, overhearing snatches of conversation, and weaving past temporal narratives into the current scene, the *flâneur* sees what might otherwise be obscured. The *flâneur*’s wanderings may be condensed into a text or map, but the resulting abstraction merely

reveals the strategy of the place: “making invisible the operation that made it possible” (de Certeau 97). Instead, the *flâneur* recreates the city as a performance. Here, one might recall Nigel Thrift’s definition of performance as, “[t]he art of producing the now” (“Performance” 577).⁶ Of course, Tim Edensor reminds us that this performance, similar to that of the contemporary tourist, “can be conceived in more ambivalent and contradictory terms, can be understood as intentional and unintentional, concerned with both being and becoming, strategically and unreflexively embodied” (“Performing Tourism” 78). This performance crafts a dynamic and paradoxical interaction between the lone observer and the crowd. Wandering the streets, the *flâneur* is both at home and rootless, alone and surrounded, ambivalent and intoxicated. From this standpoint, the *flâneur* need not be imagined as some specialized observer but rather viewed as a choice available to anyone who inhabits a complex environment: to see what other people ignore.

Having proposed *flânerie* as a lens to view the Las Vegas tourist environment, I propose we take a stroll through its passages. Doing so, we might consider the kind of place we encounter—the stage-set for contemporary urban performances that bleed beyond the “here” and “now” of tourist slogans. I didn’t visit Las Vegas simply because of its position as global intersection of tourist practices; I chose this environment because of my belief that Las Vegas enacts an enclavic urbanity that reflects an emerging reality of late modern capitalism, one that I term “omnitopia.” In the section that follows, I outline the meaning and utility of the omnitopian framework before exploring some of the stages and motifs of omnitopian performance.

Wherever You Go, There You Are

Omnitopia enacts an architectural and perceptual enclave whose apparently distinct locales (and locals) convey inhabitants to a singular place.⁷ An imperfect amalgam of Greek and Latin roots constructing an “all-place,” the term draws its lineage from utopia (non-place) and heterotopia (other-place) to reveal the shift from singular totalizing narratives to overlapping contradictory narratives. A key distinction from heterotopia, however, is omnitopia’s shift from separate locale (park, church, graveyard, motel) to complete enclosure that approximates all of urbanity. This enclosure does not reside elsewhere, but “everywhere.” Heterotopia offers a social safety valve from public life.⁸ Omnitopia, on the other hand, constructs a synecdoche of the world, one that is necessarily and strategically incomplete.⁹ While the “entire world” cannot reside within the omnitopian enclosure, one encounters enough of the world to ignore what has been elided. The archetypal omnitopian may be the traveler who flows from international airport to atrium hotel to enclosed shopping mall to theme restaurant to yet another international airport—all without ever walking the streets. Moreover, as our archetypal omnitopian flows from airport to airport, she or he comes to experience them as terminals to *the same place*.

Elsewhere I have taken a critical approach toward omnitopia, viewing it as a disciplinary place that reduces agency to a singular commodified continuum (Wood

“A Rhetoric”). In this manner, I have joined critics such as Daniel Boorstin, Edward Relph, Joshua Meyrowitz, and Marc Augé who critique the shrinking of human geography until every place becomes the same place (or non-place).¹⁰ In this critique, I have also found much insight from Mark Gottdiener who reveals the “inauthentic” nature of these environments (79). However, the implicit connection between inauthenticity and placelessness troubles me on several levels. Most obviously, it should be noted that some places are designed to induce inauthenticity and to enable pleasurable *performances of inauthenticity*. Moreover, the gathering of these places into the singularity of omnitopia does not banish the perception of place but rather evokes a new perception of place marked by the globalized self who appropriates the markers of non-place for individual purposes that range from the merely functional to the playfully ironic. This performance may include the act of reading *USA Today* in an airport, wearing Gap clothing around the office, or ordering coffee at Starbucks. Again, these may be purely functional acts, but they can also reflect public performances that revel in their inauthenticity. Even in omnitopia, we might meet “tourists” who transform non-places into their places. In the section that follows, I wander the omnitopian enclosure of Las Vegas before exploring how tourists play within (and with) its confines.

Touring Omnitopia

Visitors to Las Vegas have come to expect safe passage and fluid motion uniting an array of richly themed environments. Covered walkways, moving sidewalks, underground passages, and street crossing bridges render each themed environment—Venice, Paris, New York, and many others—into nodes of the same experience, almost impossibly distant from the city beyond. Most visitors define Las Vegas by its Strip, an enclave within an enclave. For years, Strip businesses struggled against the avalanche of walkers: they skittered between casinos, they contributed to local traffic, and they died by the dozens per year in car accidents. Today, however, the Strip is increasingly woven together to form a singular and safe experience, aided in part by pedestrian bridges. At two intersections of Las Vegas Boulevard—one at Tropicana Ave, another at Flamingo Road—four-way bridges lift pedestrians above the road. These walkways provide portals between major Strip resorts, offering unencumbered passage over the traffic that grinds along the road below. Hal Rothman describes the overhead crosswalks as “something out of Fritz Lang’s *Metropolis*, futuristic and postmodern, the foot traffic of the future” (255). The bridges draw together incommensurate themes, rendering them coherent to one another. For example, one may take a pedestrian bridge from New York-New York, with its dense mélange of urban grit, deco skyscrapers, and Lady Liberty statue, to Excalibur, with its golden chandeliers, medieval jousts, and fork-free eating. Lifting visitors above the streets and connecting them to fanciful places, the bridges contribute one component to the omnitopian enclave.

Beyond the bridges, the Las Vegas Monorail presents another level of enclave, which, by definition, requires some degree of exclusion. At a cost of \$650 million, the

monorail follows a lightning-bolt shaped path from Tropicana Avenue to Sahara Avenue. Single-ride tickets (\$3 in 2005) enable passengers to ride 4.4 miles of the Strip. Rising a minimum of 21 feet above street level, the monorail's seven stations are most easily accessible from the large hotels. Indeed, I find only a single location where a tourist may park a car and hop on the monorail.

When I visit the Flamingo/Caesars Palace Station,¹¹ I find entering the monorail from street level to be impossible since each stairway, serving as an emergency exit, is enclosed and locked from the inside. I discover an elevator to an above-street entrance, but I am unable to use it because I lack a keycard from the nearby hotel. I return to the street and wander in frustration while monorail patrons stroll along a skyway to the station above. Walking under the monorail path beyond the hotels, I survey the backs of modest apartment complexes, an occasional resort timeshare property, a laborer moving from job to job, and the undeniable sense that this place is not designed to accommodate touring walkers. Crossing between some of the resort hotels, I must become an explorer, climbing five-foot walls and dropping onto crumpled cigarette butts. In the sky above, a helicopter hangs in the air, perhaps monitoring traffic conditions for a local news affiliate. Outside of the comforting embrace of authorized places, I feel vulnerable and slightly illegal.

At last, I admit defeat and amble toward the Flamingo Las Vegas. Passing through the glass doors and riding the escalator, I am authorized, cleansed of my street distinction. Asking directions to the station, I receive friendly and patient service. Soon, I walk the skyway that previously rose above me. Inserting my ticket, compliments of New York-New York, I enter a clean and climate controlled monorail. The ride largely parallels the strip but traverses construction zones, revealing the tops of service stations, the development of golf courses, and the tons of equipment used to build the dozens of condominiums rising nearby. I have found a paradoxical home in movement, after the dizzying meander outside. I have returned to the omnitarian enclave, to the swish of electronic doors and recirculated air.

Once inside, I search for New York-New York's America the Restaurant. "America" presents tourism as a series of secondary representations. Dozens of postcard epigrams line the long interior wall across from the register: "Having a wonderful time. Will be in Grand Canyon tomorrow. We are picnicking beside the road and sleeping in motels. Wish you were here." In America, wait-staff wear blue button-down shirts with American flag ties. Super-enlarged Curt Teich-style linen "large letter" postcards, the kind with pictures in each letter, stretch across the upper walls: "Greetings from Milwaukee," "Greetings from El Paso," "Greetings from Memphis." Hanging over the main dining area, a ninety by twenty foot curved bas-relief map of the continental United States presents a fifties-vibe of American Industry: oranges in Florida, oil wells in Texas, silver mines in Nevada. The menu offers a "carica-tour" of US culinary delights: Baby Back Ribs from "Dallas," Rajun Cajun Pork from "New Orleans," Mom's Meatloaf from "Savannah," and "The Route 66 appetizer sampler" from "USA." It's like being on the Eiffel Tower with its dizzying view. The map and the menu show it all, and the intoxicating rush is even "better than the real thing." Leaving the restaurant, I spot a sign that says, "Thank you for visiting America."

One can become easily immersed in omnitopia; its performances and referents preclude meaningful or transcendent purpose outside of itself. The omnitopian locale is ever-present and pervasive, persuasive in its totality. Certainly, some places offer the illusion of depth, the possibility of multiple meanings. For example, Le Village Buffet in Paris-Las Vegas creates a convincing *mise-en-scène* with windows that reveal several receding layers, an outdoor walkway to organize the lines of hungry visitors, an inner courtyard style restaurant, and another outdoor façade to frame the serving stations. Despite its engaging and ironic play of interior and exterior worlds, the purpose of this place is to sell buffet style food to a large number of people who wish they could experience a gastronomical *Tour de France*, but may never get the chance.

I encounter omnitopia as a series of apparently individual locales, each of which is designed to deposit me into the next. Every site is strange and fantastic in a vaguely disagreeable manner, ugly and exhilarating. I slip back a bit into Walter Benjamin's stroll through the Parisian streets, where the grand and ornate stores "form the eccentric frame within which the last privateers so readily displayed themselves" (M21a, 2/455). Constant and seamless motion—aided by light rails, monorails, sliding doors and moving pathways, and even fake tours through America the Tasty, France *La Bon*—the "eccentric frames" of themed environments allow me to ignore the burning desert expanse that encloses the city, and to forget the mechanical process of consumer transfer that keeps those slot machines ringing.¹² This experience recalls the promise of Crystal Palaces throughout modern history, the ability to craft enclosed fantasies that play with natural impediments. Writing about enclosed shopping malls, Margaret Crawford offers another useful parallel: "Architects manipulated space and light to achieve the density and bustle of a city downtown—to create essentially a fantasy urbanism devoid of the city's negative aspects: weather, traffic, and poor people" (22). A snippet of recorded audio playing at the Flamingo Hotel offers, "A tropical paradise so lush, you'll forget you're in the desert." Inside omnitopia, I wonder about other tourists: how do they experience this place? Are they trapped in a carceral state or a playground? Do they wander the passages asleep or do they resist? During my strolls, I find that tourists do indeed employ a range of tactics to craft their own performances, and yet the poles of commodity empathy and critical struggle fail to adequately express their actions. Thus, I must seek a middle approach.

The Flâneur Meets the Post-Tourist

Visitors to omnitopia may encounter even the most totalizing enclosures knowingly, skillfully, and playfully. They may seek tourist traps but not imagine getting trapped by them. Maxine Feifer defines these people as "post-tourists" (see also, Urry; Ritzer and Liska). Post-tourists may be known by three qualities: they are freed from traditional tourist locales; they can experience multiple perceptions of tourism; and they are self-reflexive about their roles in the co-construction of tourist sites. In this manner, one may argue that the post-tourist performs her or his role in a manner similar to that of the *flâneur*. Both adopt a stance that conveys recognition, even

celebration, of the artificiality of the performance. Both also transform the totalizing spectacle of contemporary life into objects, snapshots, glances, and souvenirs, often in unintended ways—"dragging" new meanings upon established ones, superimposing personal meanings upon institutional ones.¹³

Most intriguingly, both experience a seemingly paradoxical relationship of intoxication and ambivalence. Intoxication stems from the pleasurable fragmentation and overlap of sensory input, the heterotopian moment in which one becomes detached from the singular narrative. Ambivalence stems from the nature of that detachment, the knowledge that one's identity and setting are artificial. After touring the Bavarian castle *Neuschwanstein*, a "real" site that inspired the design of Cinderella's castle in Anaheim's Disneyland, Paul Edwards describes feeling "caught" in such an excessively tacky environment as to demand a kind of purposeful detachment: "My ambivalence is a performance, produced and constrained by the site itself as I pass through it" (273). For the post-tourist, ambivalence serves as a reminder: "Don't get too excited. This is not real." Performing ambivalence calls for a certain detached cool, a gaze that does not linger too lengthily upon one site or another, a knowing smile that does not exude joy but rather a sense of irony.

Post-Tourists in Las Vegas

In New York-New York or Paris-Las Vegas, the post-tourist *flâneur* engages in behaviors and utterances that enable transformation and performed "knowingness." Initially, I find that photographers and videographers demonstrate the most intriguing tactics of transformation.¹⁴ After all, the photographer's gaze—the technologies of composing, editing, capturing, discarding—enables a measure of control over the environment, a means to transform it into one's personal collection of images (Urry). Chris Jenks and Tiago Neves describe this process as *détournement*: "the re-cycling, repositioning, or re-employing of the existing elements of an art work, or works, into a new synthesis" (8). Often employed by photojournalists, *détournement* reveals absurdity and unplanned relationships: The walker can "playfully and artfully 'see' the juxtaposition of the elements that make up the city in new and revealing relationships" (8). Manipulated by the photographer's gaze, places and even people become props, privatized for the purposes of individual pleasure. Here, "tourists are in effect acting protagonists who perform on the stages of tourism" (Noy 116). This phenomenon has marked the intersection of tourism and photography since its nineteenth-century inception when photography first transformed its practitioners into voyeurs, tourists watching the scene but not acting as part of the scene. The viewfinder creates the means through which one may craft the "picturesque" frame of the natural world (Löfgren). Moreover, photographers using digital cameras supersede the traditional detachment afforded by older cameras. Rather than staring through an optical viewfinder at a person or object mediated only by distance and glass, digital photographers stare at a video reproduction of the image: a second order of detachment. In a similar manner,

amateur videographers stroll the streets with eyes fixed on miniature screens that reduce even the most surreal environments to manageable proportions.

Reflecting on this, I recall sitting at the corner of one of the Eiffel Tower's four giant legs to watch the photographers and videographers. I notice that virtually everyone with some sort of camera stops to take a photo of the tower that rises above. One young girl tilts her video camera down from the spire of the Eiffel Tower to the ground before panning around to the small group of adults in her group. The tower has now become a family landmark, its position marked in relation to her loved ones. She then pans back around to a pair of men walking into the casino. One says: "She's filming your back, you know that?" The other, a guy in an Aloha-style shirt, laughs and replies: "better get a wide angle lens, man!" This narrative becomes dragged onto the scene, the tourist site transformed into a post-tourist production: fleeting, intentional, improvisational.

This improvisation calls for a performed awareness on the part of both photographers and their post-tourist subjects. Here I recall one evening under the New York-New York portico with its neon Aztec sun and the occasional idling stretch Hummer. A young woman in her early twenties waits for visitors carrying cameras. With her flowing gown, uplifted torch and glittering crown, she works as a prop, offering a human personification of New York in Las Vegas. She wears a nametag and shares some relaxed banter with the doorman. She's official, authorized, and her smile is warm and inviting. Every few minutes, folks leaving New York-New York accept her invitation to pose for a photo. One man stands with her while his female companion frames the shot. Standing next to the human-sized Statue of Liberty, the man awkwardly holds his own camera, at first, at his side. A look of confusion crosses his face. He then hides the camera behind his jeans, presumably in hopes that the photo will look less staged that way. One might imagine his intuition that every added layer of artifice diminishes the value of the image he's framed, the picture he will share with friends of a stranger outside of a casino who happened to resemble the Statue of Liberty.

Wandering the streets of "New York" on another evening, I encounter still more private performances, stylized and rehearsed exhibitions. Photo taking creates a specialized struggle given the omnipresence of crowds. Etiquette requires walkers to recognize and quickly traverse the temporary zones of privacy created by the photographer's intended shot. Such decorum can result in odd courtesies. One evening as I stand on a bridge in order to shoot the New York "skyline" I decide to sit down in search of a more dramatic angle. A teenager walks toward me unawares before nearly stepping on my feet. While I choose to sit in a public thoroughfare and take the risks that behavior deserved, it is she who profusely apologizes. Standing (or sitting), of course, contribute only one aspect of agency. *Moving* through omnitarian spaces, willfully and originally, fleshes out the body of the tourist who would control a place. Elsewhere, I catch myself in the gaze of another *flâneur*. One man leans against a light post, his video camera viewfinder flipped up. He stares intensely at the image, his brow furrowing. I look his way, figuring that I've entered his frame. He jerks the lens to his left and I am no longer part of his home movie. It appears that I

committed a rookie mistake, spoiling the shot by staring at the camera. I'm fairly certain that I was not the subject of the shot—tourists rarely photograph strangers without some external context. However, I was clearly an object within the shot and failed to recognize my proper role.

Here, I turn to the notion of performed “knowingness”—often through ironic comment—that is so essential to the post-tourist *flâneur*. Here, the performance conveys that one knows the routine. To illustrate, I find myself sitting on “Hudson Street” in New York-New York, near the plate glass window for Mike's TV Repair: a jumble of old television sets, one with exposed vacuum tubes, some set to snow, one running a local channel in black and white. The one color-screen reveals a shot of the alley where I'm perched. I see myself smoking a cheap cigar. As folks walk by chatting, as people line up for photographs of each other, I lean back a bit and suck on the cherry stogie. An older man wearing business slacks and a dress shirt selects the table next to me and catches sight of the televisions. He cranes his neck and spots the sign on the “second floor” next to a wheezing half-sized air conditioning unit. Glancing my way, he says, “Mike's TV Repair” and laughs.

In “Paris,” I return to my café under the artificial sky. I catch folks gazing upward. One man in particular stares at the faux ceiling, its fluffy white clouds mixing with the shadow of an artificial tree, and remarks to his companion, “sky blue.” She glances up and emits a brief explosive laugh. Later that afternoon, I find another spot along the promenade, across from a “street” performer who sits atop a short ladder. He is painted dull bronze and stands still, resembling a statue. Invariably folks walk by unaware before he touches them or blows a kiss. The shrieks from surprised tourists inspire laughter from others who are in on the joke. Across the path, I sit on a bench next to a real bronze statue: a workingman in bronze overalls who rests next to a lunch pail and thermos. Occasionally, someone will stop to check his vital signs. One group ambles by and a young woman sits on the man's lap. An infrared beam caresses them both before a camera flashes. A family swarms around the statue, kids kicking and slapping at the metal surface. Later, a woman peels off from her group to touch the metal man. She pronounces with confidence: “Not real.” She laughs and repeats: “Not real!” To my right, a guy in shorts and a silver ponytail stands with a smile, watching the show. After a while, I cannot help myself. I sit closer to the workingman, frozen in a similar pose, my arm hanging limply over the bench. I cannot convey the irony of my position—a relatively privileged academic posing as a statue for the gaze of others. My pose is potentially more artificial than “his” or the real workingman across the way: I can get up and leave. Even so, I revel in the pleasure of the occasional question: “Is *he* for real?”

The afternoon grows long and I head for the doors that lead to the miniature *Arc De Triomphe*. Near the door, a small coterie in a ragged collection seems intent on something, but I can't orient their gazes. Then I spot the mime. Of course, Paris-Las Vegas would have a mime. Armed with a curved plastic tickle brush, the mime waits for passers-by to cross his path. He surveys the looks, some awestruck but most blasé. He seems to prefer the latter, looking for an opportunity to tickle them. The hapless walker invariably feels a strange sensation—a fly, perhaps?—and gesticulates

cluelessly while the small crowd laughs. After a while, two or three dozen people are in on the joke, forming a thin conduit of gawkers who wait for the next victim. The pleasure of looking at those who do not know, laughing together at the inside joke, nodding at the photographers who try to capture the moments: these instances in this kind of place transform us all from strangers into post-tourist *flâneurs*.

Leaving Las Vegas

Viewing tourist locales as stage-sets for performances provides a fruitful site for scholarly inquiry. After all, these sorts of places are particularly adept at providing scripts and audiences that shape our choices—even, ironically, as we seek freedom from the disciplines of our everyday lives. Nonetheless, we find certain places to be so completely crafted, so totally rehearsed, that we imagine our roles as unassailably fixed. Fredric Jameson contributes much to this despairing account, thanks to his baffling encounter with the Los Angeles Bonaventure Hotel, a mirrored enclave that disorients even the most practiced contemporary *flâneur*. In this hyperspatial environment, Benjamin's reveries about the pleasures of urban life would appear to be "both singularly relevant and singularly antiquated in light of this new and virtually unimaginable quantum leap in technological alienation" (Jameson 45). Following Jameson's example, if not the entire spirit of his project, many scholars have bemoaned the disorientation that afflicts inhabitants in all manner of postmodern places. Rob Shields's influential analysis of the West Edmonton Mall provides a useful example wherein post-tourists become replaced by *post-shoppers* who, despite their moments of ironic detachment, nonetheless become subjects of a Foucauldian environment: "Although the promoted image is one of freedom, unfettered impulse buying, and liminality, the reality is one of control, new forms of discipline, and surveillance" ("Social Spatialisation" 160; see also Edensor *Tourists at the Taj*). In his typically trenchant style, Zygmunt Bauman adopts a similar pose, noting that in the various "Disneylands" of contemporary life—casinos, malls, amusement parks, and other "dream houses of the collective" (Benjamin's term)—the *flâneur* wanders in a manner that may be considered "aimless," even while unconsciously affirming the designs of consumer society: "There was a goldmine somewhere in the modern urge to 'wander aimlessly'; the market found it and set to exploit. Disneylands are the mineshafts" (150). In these critiques, we encounter a decidedly determinist response to the types of sites found in omnitopia, the assumption that they compel us to submit to their designs. This is not the heady submission of intentional intoxication but rather the mindless amblings found in a George Romero film.

In this essay, I have responded that post-tourist *flâneurs* are not zombies. Instead, they enact performances whose winking irony contains the possibility of agency, if not resistance.¹⁵ In this manner, I join a cohort of scholars attempting to study tourist experiences and behaviors in a more direct manner than those who only encounter representations of ideology. Initially, I am drawn to the intriguing work of Ian Woodward, Michael Emmison, and Philip Smith, who take Fredric Jameson and Rob

Shields literally when they describe the disorienting effects of late capitalist/postmodern enclosures, testing the hypothesis that people generally become confused in these sorts of totalizing environments. Aided by interviews and observations, the researchers found:

Rather than being rendered passive and irremediably confused by such locales, they are able to learn from their initially disorienting encounters with complex built forms and develop pragmatic regimes for their navigation. Far from being written in stone, then, the influence of architecture is eroded over time and consequently the fatalistic vision of the mall scholars and postmodern architectural theorists is misplaced. (350)

Woodward and colleagues add that many theorists of urban enclosures invariably confuse Walter Benjamin's notion of the *flâneur* with the related figure of the *badaud*, the gawker or the rubberneck.¹⁶ In response, I hold that the *flâneur* is awake and aware, and cannot fairly be dismissed as a mere shopper. Beyond these empirical and etymological rebukes, however, I hope that this essay contributes to an ongoing discussion about the relationship between authenticity and pleasure. Here, I have argued that the post-tourist *flâneur* does not condemn places that are artificial but rather revels in the performance of inauthenticity.

Of course, the notion that tourism rests upon an inauthentic foundation is hardly new. In his book, *The Image: A Guide to Pseudo-Events in America*, Daniel Boorstin critiqued the construction of pseudo-events (and pseudo-places) that are designed for tourists who flock to interstate highway sites such as the ubiquitous and anonymous motel, a location said by Boorstin to possess no meaning other than its service as a node within a continuum of commodification: "They prefer to be no place in particular—in limbo, en route. . . . They feel most at home above the highway itself, soothed by the auto stream to which they belong" (114). In his germinal research on tourism, Dean MacCannell gently rebukes Boorstin's overly pessimistic view by borrowing Erving Goffman's distinction between front and back stage environments. MacCannell argues that tourists seek authenticity, even though they must often settle for "staged authenticity."¹⁷ My essay has departed from MacCannell and his progenitors somewhat, returning halfway to Borstin's notion that tourists seek the inauthentic. I hold that the post-tourist knowingly engages the façade, the surface, and the fake, as a mutable substance that may be transformed into an individualized product of remembrance, a souvenir. In this way, I agree with Michael Harkin who states: "Tourists seeking casinos and kitschy public versions of traditional culture will greatly outnumber and outspend those seeking authenticity" (583).¹⁸ However, I also add that the performances of inauthenticity deserve as much attention as the places in which these performances occur.

This turn speaks to an intriguing conversation within performance scholarship concerning the possibility (and the desirability) of resistance toward an inauthentic environment. Indeed, as I noted earlier, my desire to wander the streets and pathways of Las Vegas was inspired by Tracy Stephenson Shaffer's recent essay on "constructing authenticity" in the performance of backpacking. Drawing from post-tourism

scholarship, Shaffer positions herself as the kind of tourist many of us would like to be:

I increasingly recognized my performance as transgressive, choosing and approaching tourist sites with the ability to take them at face value, recognizing them as constructions, and knowing that for everything I was seeing, there was much more I was not seeing. I was also able to impose my own counterhegemonic readings upon them. Although I was unable to get outside the apparatus of tourism, I attempted to revise it from within. (156)

Setting off for Las Vegas, I assumed that an increasing number of visitors have begun to adopt a similar pose: transgressing as post-tourists—perhaps unable to escape the “apparatus of tourism,” but able, nonetheless, to challenge its limits. This school of thought proposes that tourists can (or should) become cultural critics, choosing to conduct the oppositional readings necessary to unpack discourses of oppression. Once more, Dean MacCannell provides an illustrative example: “I could summarize the central finding of all the research I have done on tourists as follows: the act of sightseeing is itself organized around a kernel of resistance to the limitations of the tourist gaze” (“Tourist Agency” 31). Thus a critical researcher searches for signs of resistance, lest it turn out that tourists really *are* duped. Or, perhaps worse, cultural theorists have been duped by an excess desire to confirm an ideologically driven hypothesis.

Admitting that the latter possibility richly resides in my own scholarship, I now find that searching for transgression (either in the stance of the tourist, or the researcher, or the researcher who passes as a tourist) need not supply the only explanation for the performances we’ve encountered. Here, I draw inspiration from Elizabeth Wilson who sympathizes with the plight of progressive scholars:

... forever walking the tightrope of the elusive “third way,” searching for compromise between two incompatible perceptions: the sometimes dour leftist apocalypse of a carceral capitalism from which there is logically no escape, and the alternative, a seemingly rather frivolous insistence on pleasure. (71)

Brian Ott contributes to this conversation by adding a useful proposal for this “third way” by distinguishing between the ideological labor necessary to resist the hegemony of dominant meanings and the pleasure that simply reproduces the power of those meanings through uncritical submission. His “new space of pleasure” stems from paradox (196). Being simultaneously and *knowingly* aware and asleep, productive and passive, intoxicated and ambivalent: these reflect the paradoxical performance of the *flâneur* and the post-tourist. This notion of pleasure—playful and ironic—calls into question the power of places and the permanence of our subject-positions within them.

Thus we rediscover the strollers of totalizing environments, wanderers through the nodes of omnitopia that seem perpetually to lead from one consumer ploy/play to another. We find that these tourists adapt the place into their kind of space, a stage-set for their own performances. Drifting through a hyperurban matrix of themed environments, post-tourist *flâneurs* drag meanings from individual sites,

commenting upon them, framing them, and editing them on the spot or elsewhere. Here and there (and even in the “everywhere” of omnitopia) they counter what Nigel Thrift describes as the feared inevitability of a dehumanized world in which the “lifeworld is taken over by the system, ‘authentic’ spaces by programmed consumer spaces, tactics by strategies, and so on” (*Spatial Formations* 5). To be sure, their productions of consumer places—fragmented, inchoate, fleeting, and ephemeral—may not “challenge” them in a manner suitable to cultural critics, nor do they enable the experience of genuinely “authentic” relationships as imagined by the idealists among us. But these performances are meaningful enough; they affirm the potential to play in the landscapes of power. And sometimes playing is the most radical choice one can make.

Conclusion: Cameras in Paris

During my July visit to Las Vegas, I stay about two hours on the observation level of the half-sized Eiffel Tower. At first, I stare at the shadow projected by the tower over the hotel pool. The dizzy feeling of height, the power to see it all, sweeps over me. I snap photographs and hum an old Fixx song, “Cameras in Paris,” dragging my recollection of “the eighties” to this place. I recall the pleasure of that phrase, “*Je Peux Voir Le Sommet!*” But eventually, I turn away from the blistering sun, sit down in the shadow, and type notes. People circle around and notice me, but no one seems to care. Staff members pay a little more attention at first, but quickly discern that I pose no threat. One occasionally drops nuggets of trivia as she walks by; there isn’t much else to talk about. After a while, I join the queue for the elevator. A moment later, I cross the walkway and return to the ground level, once more amidst the cacophony of the casino.

During this particular trip, I’ve taken a number of photographs and collected plenty of souvenirs, including a ceramic hot air balloon container that held a strawberry daiquiri—a semiexotic reminder that I’ve actually been somewhere.¹⁹ I’ve also managed to buy a rayon shirt festooned with colorful graphics from Las Vegas’s past: a safely seductive dancing girl, some Flintstones-meets-the-Jetsons-style hotel, and that cigarette-smoking cowboy with the waving arm. The shirt transforms me into a walking retro postcard collection. But I have one more souvenir to consider: the picture they’d snapped of me before I ascended the Tower. I walk over to a desk topped with computer monitors and hand the attendant my receipts. A few clicks later, I gaze upon my own image, standing with arms outstretched. I have a crooked half-smile and eyes just slightly too wide open for this scene. I remember being told that my pose would convey how happy I was to be here. Instead, I look goofy, a little confused, maybe even drunk. I think I’d only had one daiquiri, but the picture suggests something else. At first, I imagine that I might as well buy the picture. But twenty dollars for a representation of my climb—more than twice the cost to visit the fake Tower itself—seems pretty steep. Walking away, I figure I don’t need yet another out of focus snapshot of a goofy tourist. I keep my money and head for the exit.

Notes

- [1] Unless noted otherwise, all quotations from Walter Benjamin are taken from Howard Eiland and Kevin McLaughlin's translation of *The Arcades Project*. These quotations include in-text references to the Tiedemann notation system and page numbers from the English translation.
- [2] While convention attendance has begun to edge out gambling as the prime moneymaker for Las Vegas, those slot machines are hardly idle. Jeannine DeFoe writes that casinos raked in \$6.1 billion in gambling revenues in 2003 ("Las Vegas Hits the Jackpot").
- [3] Notable examples include Bernadette Marie Calafell's recent pilgrimage to Mexico City, Paul Edwards's pilgrimage to Neuschwanstein castle, Lisa Love and Nathaniel Kohn's examination of souvenirs, Chaim Noy's research on backpacking narratives, and Tracy Stephenson Shaffer's exploration of tourist authenticity.
- [4] I am not the first communication scholar to propose that Walter Benjamin's *flâneur* can be usefully articulated from the perspective of performance. For example, Michael Bowman noted how the *flâneur*'s strolls "register all the 'shocks' of modern life, against which our psychological and cultural apparati have inoculated us, in order to recombine them into a new product" (8).
- [5] My choice of ellipses to obscure the phrases "for him," "to him," and "around him" cannot elide the debate waged by feminist-identified readers to define the *flâneur*'s role within the structure of patriarchy. Wolff has described the impossibility of the *flâneuse*, while Wearing and Wearing have sought to replace the *flâneur* with the *choraster*. Other scholars have compared the *flâneur* to the prostitute (Buck-Morss) and to the paparazzo (Jokinen and Veijola). Of course, feminist readings of the *flâneur* are no more homogenous than feminist theorists. For example, Friedberg, Gleber, Nava, and Wilson have all argued that nineteenth-century and early twentieth-century women employed comparable tactics to those of the *flâneur*.
- [6] While the post-textual turn, illustrated by Nigel Thrift's notion of nonrepresentational theory, opens new possibilities to study performances as incomplete and unfixed, scholars such as Catherine Nash warn that we must not ignore the "regulatory systems" that inscribe themselves onto bodies, particularly those gendered "female."
- [7] My notion of enclave borrows somewhat from Tim Edensor's *Tourists at the Taj*, where he describes how a "complex of facilities [hotels, restaurants, entertainment sites, and the like], frequently owned by large national and international corporations, provides a self-contained environment where tourists are encouraged (or intimidated) into spending as much money as possible" (45).
- [8] See Foucault; Hetherington; Soja "Heterotopologies," *Postmodern Geographies, Thirdspace*; Wood "Managing the Lady Managers," "The Middletons."
- [9] In previous essays I explored "aspects" of omnitopia: generic environments, continual movement, and atomized interactions (Wood "A Rhetoric") and "strategies" of omnitopia: dislocation, conflation, fragmentation, mutability, mobility, and commodification (Wood "The Best Surprise;" Wood and Todd).
- [10] For example, see Daniel Boorstin's chapter, "From Traveler to Tourist," in his book, *The Image: A Guide to Pseudo-Events in America*; Joshua Meyrowitz's chapter, "The Separation of Social Place from Physical Place," in his book, *No Sense of Place: The Impact of Electronic Media on Social Behavior*; and Edward Relph's book, *Place and Placelessness*. More recently, Marc Augé has offered a useful introduction to contemporary notions of non-place through his comparison: "If a place can be defined as relational, historical and concerned with identity, then a space which cannot be defined as relational, or historical or concerned with identity will be a non-place" (77–78). Even so, I disagree with Augé's implication that non-places present fleeting encounters with supermodernity, and that we become disembodied non-persons when passing through them.

- [11] "Caesars Palace" includes no singular possessive apostrophe because its creator, Jay Sarno, insisted that *all* guests to this property could be Caesars.
- [12] Benjamin relates the intoxication of urban life to the mechanics of gambling, noting how the artificial stimulant of the game crafts an illusory sense that each moment offers the potential to overcome an impeccably constructed machine: "This state of affairs becomes decisive in the disposition of what comprises the authentic 'intoxication' of the gambler. Such intoxication depends on the peculiar capacity of the game to provoke presence of mind through the fact that, in rapid succession, it brings to the fore constellations which work—each one wholly independent of the others—to summon up in every instance a thoroughly new, original reaction from the gambler" (O12a, 2/512–13).
- [13] Chris Rojek identifies how tourists and post-tourists "drag" signs from an increasingly sprawling index of "files," weaving them among their personal experiences: "By encrusting the original object with secondary images, values and associations, these processes make us lose sight of the original meaning of the object. It becomes, as it were, co-opted to fulfill temporary, immediate personal or cultural interpretations" (59). Like the *flâneur*, the post-tourist drags any number of meanings across the seemingly impenetrable façade of the built environment, crafting personal meanings that may resist authority or, more frequently, play with it.
- [14] Here, I push somewhat against the boundaries of *flânerie* as imagined by Walter Benjamin. Concerned with the declining power of "aura," Benjamin's critique of photography is well known. Yet, in his essay, "The Work of Art in the Age of Mechanical Reproduction," Benjamin admits that photography offers a powerful, even revolutionary, potential—once freed from the fetish of authenticity: "Here the camera intervenes with the resources of its lowerings and liftings, its interruptions and isolations, its extensions and accelerations, its enlargements and reductions. The camera introduces us to unconscious optics as does psychoanalysis to unconscious impulses" (*Illuminations* 237). Susan Sontag adds that Benjamin himself constructed an almost cinematic montage of texts, employing much of the photographer's art/craft (77).
- [15] One might recall Judith Hamera's recent reminder: "That such doings may be banal rather than obviously subversive makes them no less meaningful or constitutive" (95).
- [16] Benjamin quotes Victor Fournel's distinction between the *flâneur* who "is always in full possession of his individuality" and the *badaud* who is "absorbed by the external world . . . which moves him to the point of intoxication and ecstasy" (M6, 5/429). Once more, Benjamin's ambivalence emerges: this time, regarding the nature of intoxication. Throughout the *Arcades Project*, intoxication (sometimes related to hashish consumption, sometimes arising from Benjamin's interests in mysticism and surrealism) appears as a motive power to the *flâneur*, while other instances suggest that intoxication deadens the potential for critical detachment. Benjamin's more critical view resides alongside his concern for submission into commodity culture along with a similar submission he witnessed in the rallies of fascist Europe. In response, I imagine a kind of performed intoxication in which, to put it bluntly (with the aid of an American colloquialism), one takes a sip but does not drink the Kool-aid. This manner of intoxication—not distraction—enables a slippage between the present moment and a range of parallel moments, each commenting upon and critiquing the other. For Benjamin, "[t]hat anamnestic intoxication in which the *flâneur* goes about the city not only feeds on the sensory data taking shape before his eyes but often possesses itself of abstract knowledge—indeed, of dead facts—as something experienced and lived through" (M1, 5/417). See also Benjamin *Charles Baudelaire* 69; Stierle 348; Shaya para. 19.
- [17] MacCannell's notion of staged authenticity has inspired more than three decades of tourism research. He writes: "it is always possible that what is taken to be entry into a back region is really entry into a front region that has been totally set up in advance for touristic visitation" ("Staged Authenticity" 597).

- [18] Matthew Spangler adds that “authenticity” itself becomes a contested terrain: “obscured, fragmented, confused, and ultimately lost in a complex web of signification that promises the genuine article but is always unable to deliver” (126). See also Balme; Fife; and Kennedy.
- [19] Love and Kohn explain this process: “As if intuitively, postmodern subjects realize they cannot rely on chance or trust their intellect, and they seize the moment [and the place], acquiring and possessing souvenirs, material objects that assure them a link with the past, with another place, with an Other” (52). Of course, the Other is not necessarily exotic, “bound up and released in reckless fantasies of the exotic, the primitive, the dark, the authentic, the erotic, the forbidden” (55). Similarly, the souvenir need not be a “tactical weapon” (61) but, rather, may bring pleasure for its banality.

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